Unpacking the FLN Gap: Systemic Challenges in Indian School Education

INTRODUCTION

This section presents a synthesis of literature examining the systemic challenges underlying the Foundational Literacy and Numeracy (FLN) gap in Indian school education. Drawing on reports from NITI Aayog, PRS Legislative Research, CESS, iJRASET, and independent scholars such as Mahanta, Mehta, and Jhingran, the synthesis traces four interlinked problem areas — funding and resource allocation, the digital divide, teacher training deficits, and weak NGO-government collaboration. Rather than treating these as isolated findings, the discussion highlights where sources corroborate, complicate, or sharpen one another's conclusions, revealing a layered and self-reinforcing set of barriers rather than a single point of failure.

Funding & Resource Allocation Gaps

Allocation shortfall: Actual spending has remained around 4% of GDP, consistently falling short of the Kothari Commission/NEP 2020 target of 6%(NITI Aayog #). This finding is similarly corroborated by statistical trend data showing expenditure ranging between 2.8% and 4.36% of GDP from 2015–2022 (CESS). Because two methodologically distinct sources arrive at the same conclusion, the shortfall appears to be a durable pattern rather than an isolated measurement.

Utilization gap: However, allocation alone does not fully explain the problem. Whereas infrastructure is broadly flagged as "underutilised due to inadequate operational budgets" (NITI Aayog #), this is substantiated by quantifying the issue at the scheme level, showing funds proposed versus released under SSA have been shrinking (PRS Legislative Research). It further identifies the underlying mechanism: a parliamentary committee linked fund-release delays directly to states' own delays in utilizing prior funds (PRS Legislative Research), suggesting, in contrast to a one-time inefficiency, a self-reinforcing cycle

Fragmentation across funding channels: In addition to utilization concerns, poor convergence between government schemes, CSR, and philanthropy is identified as a distinct structural problem, with District Convergence Plans recommended (NITI Aayog #). This represents a coordination failure separate from, though compounding, both the allocation and utilization gaps above.

Uneven impact across education levels: Compared to higher education, where GER rose sharply from 27.4% to 39.7% (2020–2024), primary enrollment stayed flat (CESS), a divergence confirmed not merely descriptively but statistically, through t-testing (CESS). A parallel, scheme-level finding shows SSA teacher training expenditure has declined since 2018-19 even as the scheme's overall budget has grown (PRS Legislative Research), indicating that the FLN-relevant component is shrinking despite, not because of, overall funding trends.

Digital Divide (Digital Classroom Equipment Gaps)

Infrastructure expansion vs. residual gap: Computer availability rose from 26.42% (2014-15) to 64.7% (2024-25), with internet similarly expanding from 8.05% to 63.5% (NITI Aayog #), corroborated by UDISE+ 2024-25 data (63.5%, up from 53.9%) (Education for all in India) However, Economic Survey 2024-25 places internet access at only ~53% (Deccan Herald #) — a discrepancy likely reflecting differing methodologies, worth flagging rather than reconciled.

A precondition gap beneath infrastructure: Even where connectivity looks encouraging, over 25,000 schools still lack electricity entirely (Education for all in India), a barrier computer and the internet cannot resolve independently. This suggests the divide is layered, with electricity a precondition beneath the connectivity gap (NITI Aayog #).

Rural-urban and interstate disparity: Consistent with NITI Aayog's state data — computer access from near-universal in Lakshadweep (100%) to 19.7% in Meghalaya (iJRASET #)broadens this into a rural-urban framing, arguing access remains unevenly distributed despite interventions like PM eVIDYA and BharatNet, and in some dimensions is widening rather than narrowing.

Usage-level and gender divide beyond access: Distinct from infrastructure, a usage divide persists: household smartphone access is near-universal (90.2% boys, 88.1% girls), yet personal ownership drops sharply (36.2%, 26.9%), with gender gaps in digital safety skills (NITI Aayog #) reinforcing iJRASET's claim that gender remains a persistent axis of the divide, independent of aggregate gains

Teacher Training Deficits

Training exists, but lacks depth and continuity: Training sessions are frequent in name but shallow in practice: 83% of trained teachers in Kamrup attended only a single FLN session (Mahanta #)consistent with NITI Aayog's national finding that in-service training remains fragmented and lecture-based; complicating this further, (Mehta)distinguishes "trained" from "professionally qualified" teachers — while 92% are trained in the broad sense, 10–12 lakh lack the specific NCTE-mandated qualification, a workforce the size of Tamil Nadu's entire teaching staff, suggesting the gap is not only about session frequency but a deeper conflation in how "trained" is even measured.

The regulator is itself under-resourced: Strikingly, NCTE is responsible for overseeing 16,000 teacher education institutions, operate with 54–89% of its own posts vacant (Mehta), mirroring, at a higher level, NITI Aayog's finding that DIETs face over 50% faculty vacancies in some states, suggesting the deficit is regulatory as much as pedagogical.

Structural burdens undercut training's impact: Non-teaching duties consume nearly 14% of planned teaching days nationally (NITI Aayog #), echoed and sharpened by Mahanta's finding of teachers in Kamrup burdened with survey and data-entry work amid pupil-teacher ratios exceeding 40:1; providing the macro backdrop, Mehta's data shows secondary-level vacancies nearly doubling in a year, meaning remaining teachers absorb both instructional and administrative loads meant for unfilled posts.

Materials blunt even successful training: Even where training does occur, its use is undermined by scarcity: only 38% of Kamrup teachers used numeracy kits regularly, with 35% reporting kits damaged or incomplete (Mahanta), consistent with NITI Aayog's broader finding of weak academic support systems failing to reinforce training after the fact.

Weak NGO and Expert Collaboration

Coordination exists on paper but remains fragmented in practice: NITI Aayog flags fragmented CSR-NGO-philanthropy coordination, recommending District Convergence Plans (Niti Aayog #). On a different note, Jhingran finds governments often sign MOUs with 10–30 non-profits simultaneously, causing overlap rather than alignment (Jhingran #) suggest the problem is not scarcity of partners but poor sequencing among them.

Short funding cycles undercut long-term change: Ramesh argues CSR should build capacity over a sustained horizon rather than "plug gaps" (Ramesh and Ameshi), Similarly, Jhingran notes most domestic funding ties to short-term outcomes, while real system change needs 7–10 years, with over 90% of long-horizon funding coming from foreign sources (Jhingran #)- two perspectives converging on the same diagnosis.

Government-side instability undermines continuity: Whereas NITI Aayog treats this as a funding-coordination issue, Jhingran highlights leadership turnover- five Project Directors in three years in some states often rolling back prior work (Jhingran #)

Data generation outpaces its use: NITI Aayog flags underutilised data systems (NITI Aayog #), Jhingran sharpens this, noting Uttar Pradesh collects 20 million data points monthly, yet little gets analysed or acted upon (Jhingran #).

CONCLUSION

Taken together, these four strands point to a common underlying pattern**: India's FLN gap** is not the product of any single deficiency but of compounding, mutually reinforcing failures across funding, infrastructure, human capital, and coordination. Insufficient allocation is worsened by poor utilization of what is allocated; digital infrastructure gains are undercut by more basic preconditions like electricity and by persistent gender and regional disparities; teacher training initiatives exist in name but are shallow, under-resourced, and blunted by material scarcity and administrative overload; and even where funding and expertise are available through **NGOs and CSR**, fragmented coordination, short funding horizons, and administrative turnover erode continuity. What emerges is a systemic rather than sectoral problem — one where interventions targeting a single gap are likely to be undermined by unaddressed weaknesses elsewhere in the system. Addressing the FLN crisis, therefore, will require converging reforms that treat funding, infrastructure, teacher capacity, and institutional coordination as interdependent rather than separate policy tracks.

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